

1. Observable Behaviors & Actions

Use these verbs and phrases to describe what you directly see a child doing.

These action words describe visible, observable behaviors without interpreting motive or assigning labels. Pair them with specifics: who, when, where, how long, how often.

Movement & Physical Actions		
ran toward	walked away from	climbed onto
sat beside	stood near	moved to the edge of
lay on the floor	reached for	pointed to
pushed away	pulled toward	turned away from
covered with hands	rocked back and forth	jumped up and down
spun in place	flapped hands	tapped repeatedly
rolled on the floor	crouched down	leaned against
paced back and forth	dropped to the ground	picked up
carried	placed down gently	threw onto

Vocal & Communication Actions		
said (exact words)	repeated	called out
asked for	pointed and vocalized	made sounds such as
cried	laughed	hummed
sang	whispered	shouted
echoed what was said	did not respond verbally	responded after a pause of
used gestures to indicate	shook head yes/no	nodded
waved	made eye contact	looked away when spoken to
looked toward the speaker		

Task & Activity Actions		
picked up materials	put down materials	completed the task
stopped after step one	attempted three times	left the activity after
returned to the activity	watched before joining	joined after two minutes
requested help by	worked independently for	required one-to-one support to
completed with a visual cue	finished with verbal prompting	did not attempt
chose the same material each time	switched materials frequently	

Social Actions		
played beside	played with	approached a peer
moved away from a peer	watched peers from a distance	offered a toy to
took a toy from	waited for a turn	did not wait for a turn
entered a peer's play	exited the group	smiled at
hugged	made a facial expression such as	initiated conversation by saying
responded to a peer by		